



ANDREA HERNÁNDEZ BRICEÑO/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

A father mourns his ‘hero’ son

José Salvador Rodríguez, a Venezuelan soldier, was killed during the U.S. operation in Caracas

BY ANDREA HERNÁNDEZ BRICEÑO, TERRENCE MCCOY AND ANA VANESSA HERRERO IN CARAYACA, VENEZUELA

In the lonely house at the edge of the forest, an old man picked through the detritus of his life. Over here was the bed he and his wife had shared for decades. Over there, the trumpet his son had played in the military marching band. And here was his faded image of Hugo Chávez, giving a military salute in his red beret.

All of it, gone now. His wife was dead, taken by illness in the summer. The socialist movement Chávez once led seemed as faded as the photo Salvador Rodríguez, 74, held in his calloused hands. And now his son, the boy who’d always asked for Rodríguez’s blessings, who’d helped him through the anguish of his wife’s passing, had been taken from him, too — killed in an explosion during the mission by U.S. forces to capture Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro. “I have his cédula right here,” he said, pulling out the seared identification card of José Salvador Rodríguez, 32, who had served as a member of the Venezuelan military. “It was burned by the explosion.”

Like many other impoverished households across

Venezuela, theirs was a family that had believed in everything Chávez and Chavismo had promised. In a nation where White political elites once controlled most of the nation’s oil wealth and power, Chávez, a career military officer of Afro-Venezuelan heritage, was among the first to recognize people who looked like himself — Black, poor, marginalized.

Following his 1998 election to the presidency, Chávez harnessed an oil boom to fund social programs that educated, fed and housed struggling Venezuelans in Tirima, the wooded enclave on the outskirts of Carayaca where Rodríguez lived with his wife and son, and places like it.

Soon, however, the oil run came to an end, Chávez was dead, killed by cancer in 2013, and the socialist “revolution” he’d left to Maduro had been handicapped by corruption, cronyism, incompetence and U.S.-led sanctions.

But Rodríguez still believed. So had his son, José. SEE VENEZUELA ON A13

Salvador Rodríguez, 74, at the grave of his son, José Salvador Rodríguez, in Carayaca, Venezuela. The younger Rodríguez was killed in the U.S. operation in the country.

Hundreds feared killed as protests intensify in Iran

U.S. OFFICIALS CONSIDER MILITARY STRIKES

Security forces escalating violence, rights groups say

BY YEGANEH TORBATI, SUSANNAH GEORGE AND JOHN HUDSON

ISTANBUL — Hundreds of demonstrators have been killed in Iran, rights groups said Sunday, as reports of a dramatic escalation in the use of deadly force by security forces began to break through a communications blackout imposed by authorities struggling to contain some of the largest protests since the Islamic republic was founded in 1979.

Trump administration national security officials, meanwhile, were preparing to discuss options, including possible military strikes, a senior U.S. official told The Washington Post.

The Center for Human Rights in Iran, based in New York, said it had received eyewitness accounts

and credible reports that hundreds of protesters have been killed since the government shut down access to the internet Thursday night. The Human Rights Activists News Agency, also based in the United States, said 490 protesters had been killed since the protests began Dec. 28.

A senior Western official who was briefed on the matter said hundreds were killed in 48 hours of protests. The official, who spoke on the condition of anonymity because he was not authorized to brief the media, said the spread of protests across a wide geographical area made it difficult to gather credible casualty figures.

The Trump administration is considering military options in SEE IRAN ON A15

Monitoring of ICE in spotlight after killing

Volunteers track, protest immigration officers, actions they say are legal

BY MOLLY HENNESSY-FISKE, TEO ARMUS, ERIN PATRICK O’CONNOR AND ROBERT KLEMKO

MINNEAPOLIS — While patrolling for Immigration and Customs Enforcement with other volunteers, two days after an officer from the federal agency fatally shot a woman in her car in this city, Sagal Ali repeated a mantra: “We will not obstruct their path. We are not

escalating.”

A text chat alerted her group while driving on Friday that ICE was near Soma Grill and Deli. They drove over to find officers circling the restaurant, masked, in an unmarked SUV. Blowing whistles from open car windows to notify the neighborhood, the group made eye contact with the officers in their vehicle, then tailed them until they left.

As the Trump administration deploys thousands of federal immigration officers and agents around the nation, a loose-knit but increasingly organized network of activists is tracking their whereabouts and documenting arrests.

SEE ICE ON A6

Data shows extent of cuts to federal workforce

A vast majority of the 335,000 employees who left quit or retired

BY MERYL KORNFIELD AND CLARA ENCE MORSE

More than a third of the Agriculture Department’s food inspectors left government last year. Over a quarter of Social Security’s IT management is gone. The Treasury Department is down about 4,000 tax examiners, or about 26 percent.

In total, about 335,000 federal workers left government from January to November 2025, with a vast majority of those people quitting or retiring, according to data released Thursday by the federal government’s human resources arm. While Trump officials and billionaire Elon Musk had vowed to fire many federal employees — accusing the work-

SEE AGENCIES ON A5

Trump’s all-out blitz on the midterm elections

Eyeing a potential loss of congressional control, he’s going to unprecedented lengths to change the rules

BY PATRICK MARLEY AND YVONNE WINGETT SANCHEZ

Five years ago, President Donald Trump pressured Republican county election officials, state lawmakers and members of Congress to find him votes after he lost his reelection bid. Now, he’s seeking to change the rules before ballots are cast.

Trump, openly fearful that a Congress controlled by Democrats could investigate him, impeach him and stymie his agenda, is using every tool he can find to try to influence the 2026 midterm elections and, if his party loses, sow doubt in their validity. Many of these endeavors go far beyond typical political persuasion, challenging long-established democratic norms.

They include unprecedented demands that Republican state lawmakers redraw congressional districts before the constitutionally required 10-year schedule, the prosecution of political opponents, a push to toughen voter registration rules and attempts to end the use of voting machines and mail ballots.

The administration has gutted the role of the nation’s cybersecu-



ILLUSTRATION BY LUCY NALAND/THE WASHINGTON POST

rity agency in protecting elections; stocked the Justice Department, Homeland Security Department and FBI from top to bottom with officials who have denied the legitimacy of the 2020 election; given a White House audience to people who, like the president, promote the lie that he won the 2020 election; sued over state and local election policies Trump opposes; and called for a new census that excludes noncitizens. The wide-ranging efforts seek to expand on some of the strategies he and his advisers and allies used to try to reverse the 2020 results that culminated in the attack on the U.S. Capitol on Jan. 6, 2021.

“I’m concerned about chaos and uncertainty in the administration of the 2026 election,” said Nathaniel Persily, a Stanford Law School professor who specializes in democracy and elections-related law. “There is a kind of avalanche of potential changes that are being proposed, and it’s at a time when people have lost trust in the election infrastructure and everybody’s on edge.”

In a statement, White House spokeswoman Abigail Jackson SEE MIDTERMS ON A8

In Nigeria, some U.S. missiles did not detonate

Experts question strike’s effectiveness, as targets, damage remain unclear

This article is by Abiodun Jamii, Joyce Sohyun Lee, Rachel Chason, Alex Horton and Isaac Arnsdorf

OFFA, NIGERIA — When President Donald Trump announced U.S. airstrikes in Nigeria on Christmas night, he declared that his newly rebranded War Department had conducted “numerous perfect strikes” against “ISIS Terrorist Scum.”

But warheads in four of the 16 Tomahawk missiles that were fired that night appeared not to explode, according to Nigerian officials, analysts and imagery reviewed by The Washington Post. Residents said one of the unexploded munitions landed in an onion field in the village of Jabo, in northwest Nigeria, while another SEE NIGERIA ON A16

IN THE NEWS

Mississippi synagogue fire A suspect is in custody and charged with arson in connection with a blaze that charred Jackson’s only Jewish house of worship. A11

A political shift Trump administration attempts to grab control of colleges and universities could have lasting effects. A3

THE NATION Last year’s Los Angeles fires uncovered the dangers of urban blazes. A2
Supreme Court Justice Neil M. Gorsuch could be the swing vote in a closely watched transgender rights case. A7

THE WORLD A retired general still holds political sway in Ukraine despite being sent to Britain as an ambassador. A12
Protests in Iran have a different feel, Ishaan Tharoor writes. A15

THE ECONOMY The housing market is easing as the number of Americans with very low mortgage rates begins to fall. A20
U.S. stocks had a good year in 2025. But stocks around the globe had a better one thanks to a flight of capital toward Europe and Asia. A20

STYLE For Erika Kirk, the wife of the late activist Charlie Kirk, pantsuits are about femininity rather than feminism. B1
The Washington National Opera’s split with the Kennedy Center is for the best, writes critic Michael Andor Brodeur. B1

SPORTS The 49ers knock out the defending champion Eagles, 23-19, on the road in the first round of the NFL playoffs. C1
METRO Hundreds attended a march through downtown Washington protesting the killing of Renée Good. C8

BUSINESS NEWS.....A20
COMICS.....B4
OBITUARIES.....C10
OPINION PAGES.....A18
TELEVISION.....B6
WORLD NEWS.....A12

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